Numbers & deadlines

The thresholds, dates, clocks and lead times that decide how fast a federal deal can move. Keep it next to your pipeline.

DOLLAR THRESHOLDS

How the buy is run depends on the size

$15,000	Micro-purchase threshold: usually a purchase card, minimal competition
$350,000	Simplified acquisition threshold: faster, simpler procedures
Above $350K	Full procedures, unless an existing vehicle, OTA or SBIR Phase III applies

Thresholds as adjusted for inflation on October 1, 2025. Next scheduled adjustment: 2030.

FISCAL CALENDAR

The year runs October 1 to September 30

Q1 Oct–Dec	Usually under a CR; new starts wait
Q2 Jan–Mar	Appropriations often land; budget request in Feb
Q3 Apr–Jun	Plan Q4 awards; markups begin
Q4 Jul–Sep	The surge; one-year money expires Sep 30

Congress has passed all regular appropriations on time only four times since 1977.

COLORS OF MONEY

How long each type can be committed

O&M · 1 yr	Running things: services, sustainment, subscriptions, training
RDT&E · 2 yr	Prototypes, pilots and testing
PROC · 3 yr	Production quantities
MILCON · 5 yr	Buildings and facilities
RECON · to FY29	One-time mandatory defense money outside the annual cycle: a CR doesn't freeze it, and most must be obligated by Sep 30, 2029

CLOCKS AFTER THE AWARD

Miss these and you lose the option

3 days	Request a debrief (negotiated procurements), in writing
10 days	GAO protest deadline, generally from when you knew the basis
100 days	GAO decides a protest; work is often paused
12 months	SAM.gov registration renewal

Deadlines vary by procurement type. Check the solicitation and the rules that apply.

TYPICAL LEAD TIMES

From first conversation to award

~6 weeks	Purchase card buy under $15,000
~4–5 months	Order on an existing vehicle
~6 months	OTA prototype, or SBIR Phase III
12–18 months	Full and open competition
2+ years	A new line in the budget (program of record)

SECURITY & ELIGIBILITY

Pass/fail before anything else counts

CMMC L1	Annual self-assessment (federal contract information)
CMMC L2	Self or third-party assessment (controlled unclassified info)
CMMC L3	Government-led assessment for the most sensitive work
FCL	Sponsored by a customer or cleared prime; months to process
Rule of Two	Two capable small businesses expected → set-aside